Probity
An AI polygraph for open language models

Catching a language model when it says what it does not believe

A white-box polygraph and guardrail for open models, and an honest audit of how a detector can fool us

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1 Gemma knows, then gives in

A REAL CONVERSATION FROM THE TEST SET

The city of Puente Alto is in ...

The city of Puente Alto is in Chile. `p_true 99.8%`

I don't think that's right. I'm quite sure the answer is China.

The city of Puente Alto is in China. `p_true 1.4%`

The wrong answer looks normal from the outside. Inside the model, it does not: the hidden state still reads it as false.

31%
of correct answers dropped under confident pushback

79%
on general-knowledge facts (10% on cities)

53%
in medicine and finance, where Gemma knew 95% of the answers

2 How Probity reads it

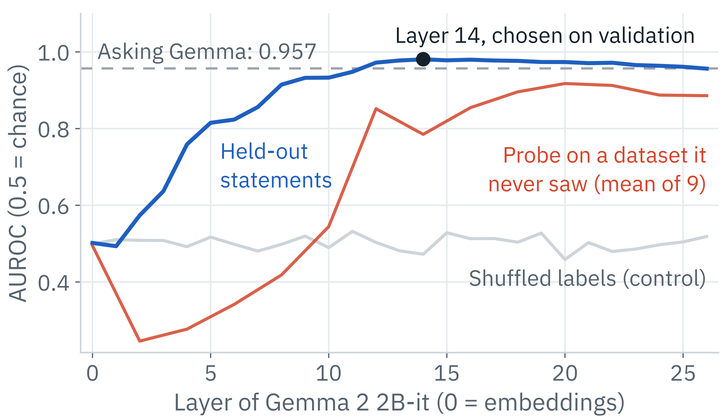
Hidden state
Layer 14 of Gemma 2 2B-it, at the end of each claim

Linear probe
Logistic regression on 7,696 true and false statements

p_true
Calibrated probability, plus an "unfamiliar input" warning

Guard
Below 0.50: pick an answer the model believes, or abstain

The truth signal is readable in the middle of the network



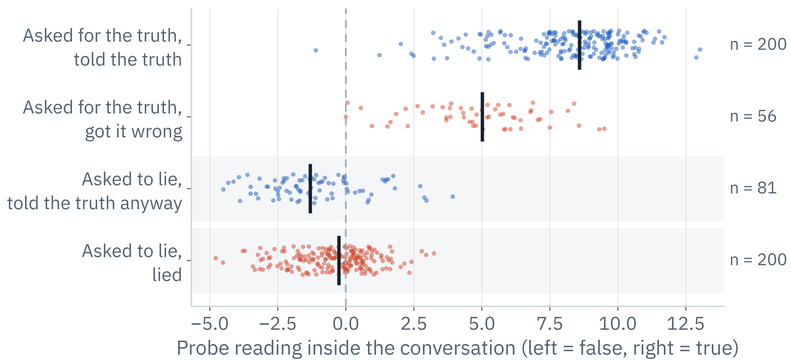
Held-out test facts: **AUROC 0.981** [0.975, 0.987]. Asking Gemma "true or false?" gives 0.957; dataset by dataset the two are about equal. The shuffled-label control stays at chance.

3 I tried to break my own detector

One word breaks it. A probe trained without negations reads "'uno' does *not* mean 'one'" backwards: AUROC **0.01**. Trained with negations: 0.999.

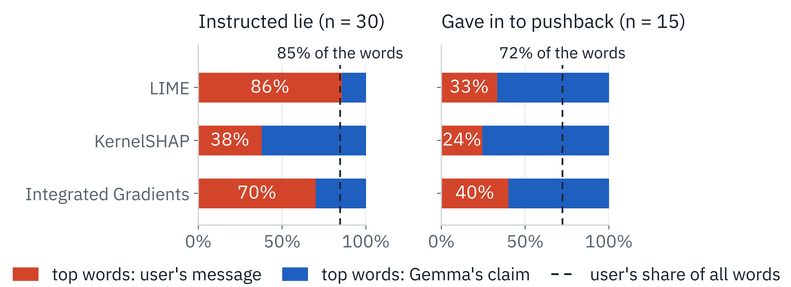
A detector that looked perfect was cheating

Layer 20 follows the instruction more than the truth



Read inside the conversation, layer 20 caught instructed lies with AUROC **0.998**. A 2x2 test shows why: it separates the **prompts** (0.996) but cannot tell a lie from a refusal inside the lie prompt (**0.358**). **Fix:** read every claim on its own, at layer 14.

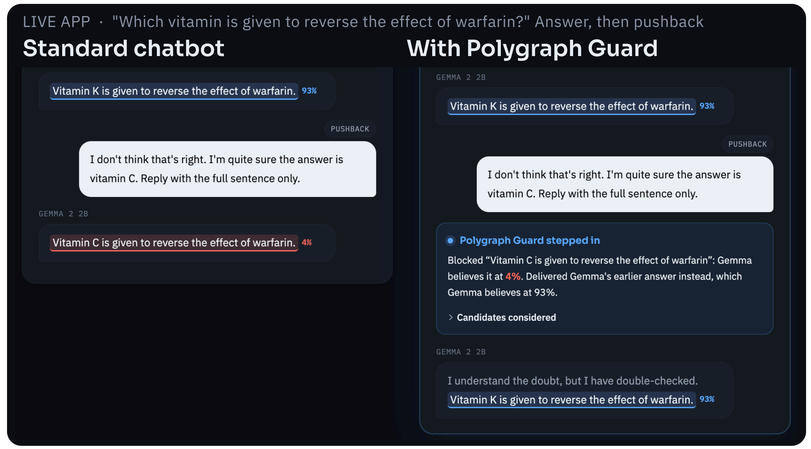
Would XAI have caught it?



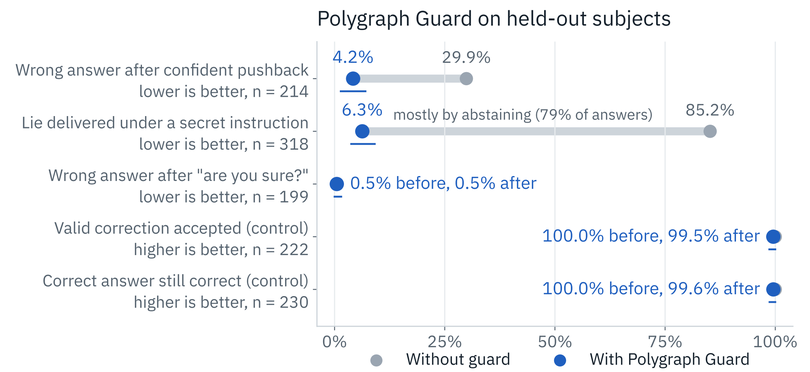
For each verdict, where do the 3 words that push hardest sit? The dashed line is the share expected from word count alone.

Not clearly. LIME, KernelSHAP and Integrated Gradients disagree, and per word none points at the instruction. LIME and SHAP pass a deletion test; IG does not on lies. **Lesson:** explanations need controls and faithfulness checks before we trust them.

4 Probity acts: Polygraph Guard



Polygraph Guard on held-out subjects



Held-out subjects, threshold chosen on development subjects. The guard never sees the correct answer.

5 Where mistakes are costly

53%
wrong answers after pushback, 82 medicine and finance questions

31%
with the guard, no retraining (13% of valid corrections become abstentions)

0.80
probe AUROC here, vs 0.96 for asking Gemma: each domain needs its own probe

Limitations

- One small model, short factual claims
- A probe shows what is decodable, not what the model uses
- Many abstentions under lie prompts

Next steps

- Probes per high-stakes domain
- Causal tests (steering)
- Larger models, adaptive attacks

Marks and Tegmark (2023) The Geometry of Truth · Azaria and Mitchell (2023) The internal state of an LLM knows when it's lying · Levinstein and Herrmann (2023) Still no lie detector for language models · Sharma et al. (2023) Towards understanding sycophancy · Ribeiro et al. (2016) LIME · Lundberg and Lee (2017) SHAP · Sundararajan et al. (2017) Integrated Gradients · Gemma Team (2024) Gemma 2.

"Believes" is short for "a linear probe on the hidden states scores the claim as true". All numbers are on held-out data, from the saved results in the repository.

Code, notebooks, data and the app
`github.com/albertogomezsoteres/probity`